The Hat on the Handle

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 2, Episode 5

A hat hung over Reed Hut's door handle. Its brim covered the letter flap and most of the caretaker's hanging notice. The caretaker was working in the reeds, so the first delivery needed to follow the instructions left behind. Nib peered beneath the brim as if it might answer him.

“A hat has taken the postman’s job,” Nib whispered suspiciously. “It is keeping the handle warm,” Lark suggested kindly.

Lark opened an earlier journal page on a flat, dry surface. Nib steadied its lower corner. One familiar word waited for another look.

“Try our earlier word before we start,” Lark invited gently. “You can sound it out or ask for help.”

> **cat**

“Lowercase h starts hat,” Lark modeled softly. “Let your breath flow gently: /h/. No hum. Join h, a, t into hat. Now change the middle vowel for hot. Hear the difference before you read the notice.”

“Join the parts and check the whole meaning,” Lark invited gently. “You can hear a part again whenever you want.”

On a little practice strip, you could try hat, hot, ham, hip, hop. Lark supplied unfamiliar story names herself. Nib waited while you looked right through each word.

“Read hat on the hanging notice,” Lark invited gently. “Which thing has been left over the flap?”

A short passage stayed in view. Lark paired each needed capital with its lowercase form and familiar sound before you began, leaving the sentence meanings for you to discover.

“Read the sentences in order,” Lark invited gently. “Let your finger follow if it helps. When you are ready, use the words to answer our question.”

> **Sam had ham. Pat had hot ham.**

“Whose ham was hot?” Lark asked gently. “Find the extra describing word.”

Lark kept the passage open so you could point to the part that helped. Nib listened before adding the picture.

Nib moved the hat to its proper hook. The flap appeared below it. He lifted the whole courier bag, then remembered its separate pockets. Lark read the destination on the Reed Hut envelope and posted that invitation alone. The caretaker's note promised a reply in this same flap on the return journey. Two invitations remained packed.

“Let's keep a written clue,” Lark suggested warmly. “Write h beside our picture. You can look at the example, follow it first, or try your own version. Then reread what you made.”

Your journal gained its first completed delivery. Lark marked the flap as the place to collect the reply. Then the crew followed the Mill path, leaving the hat on its hook and the invitation safely inside.